

frameworks for the database. We are using MySQL, Redis, MongoDB, et al. Everything we do is essentially open source based.”

Zopper’s CTO believes that open source technologies can do it all. He says, “I have been using open source for over 17-18 years, right since my college days when we used to get Linux on floppies. My encounter with open source technology began with some Linux CDs provided with magazines. Even during my college days, I started a few small ventures based on open source technologies. At that time, Perl was a popular language. I used to experiment with code and that was a whole lot of fun. This ‘fun’ aspect of Linux has been the driving force behind my passion for open source technologies. And I continue having fun in my career too. Prior to my job at Zopper, I was a technical consultant with many companies, where I propagated open source technologies. I also worked with Macmillan, where I switched a lot of their processes to open source.”

It’s just about the innumerable advantages...

When you talk to an open source fan like Baweja, you know you will get nothing but the positives about this freedom-friendly technology. He has his reasons for banking on open source technology. He shares, “The best thing is that open source technology allows access to the code, allowing techies like us to have full control of the system. Open source technologies, of course, are free and affordable. They are essentially driven by an entire community and that is a big advantage. Using open source technologies allows us to be a part of that entire community’s ecosystem, where other tech majors are also contributing. With so many players being a part of a product’s development, the robustness of the product increases manifold.”

The other advantage is the scalability he gets with open source technology. He says, “Zopper is India’s largest hyper-local mobile marketplace featuring over 500,000 offline retailers. Founded by serial entrepreneurs Surjendu Kuila and Neeraj Jain, Zopper taps the benefits of shopping at a retail store, and combines them with the convenience of shopping via mobile phones. Users can buy from the comfort of their homes/offices and get the product instantly from their nearby trusted stores. And in all these efforts, technology is at the forefront. If we need to add more and more retailers and customers, we need technology that allows scalability. With

open source, you definitely have the bandwidth to scale as much as you want.”

The community is really important...

About interacting with the community, Baweja says, “Yes, we do that a lot. We try and participate in every possible way. While we participate in events like PyCon and other similar conferences, we also closely interact with the communities around Python, Django and other such technologies that we use. As far as our contributions go, though we have contributed some bits and pieces to the community in the past, it’s not as much as we would like to do. That is definitely going to be one of our focus areas in the future.”

Want a job at Zopper? Update your GitHub profile

Zopper houses an engineering team of about 40 people. And the company has a very unique way of hiring too. Baweja says, “Our standard hiring process involves solving a problem and submitting it in GitHub. We look at candidates’ GitHub profiles and evaluate the kind of work they have done. Essentially, we look for problem solvers. Knowledge of a specific technology is not all that important. What we look at is the right attitude to handle a problem and a situation. In a nutshell, we look at the core engineering skills and the problem-solving attitude. I believe that if someone is good with Java, they can also work with Python or any other programming language. Learning a programming language is simple, if someone has the problem-solving attitude. Open source technologies contribute a lot in that direction. I know people who randomly keep installing open source technologies that are available, and try them out and figure out what all can be done with them. So it is the ‘other way round’ approach. Instead of looking for a solution, we look for what best can be done with a piece of software and then fit it as a solution. I believe that people who do that, have a much better approach towards problem solving.”

The disadvantages are non-existent

Baweja concludes, “from Zopper’s perspective, I don’t think we have faced any disadvantage by using open source technologies. However, larger corporates may face some bottlenecks if they use open source. They may want instant solutions, and not have all the time to explore the options and solve the problems in the open source domain. We handle such issues ourselves, so this is not a disadvantage for us.” 